

Framing anyone?

Macroblocking is a glitch where the smooth video flow temporarily dissolves into blocks

DTH losses

Sun Direct suffers huge losses between the August - October period

How old is TV?

The first successful public television broadcast happened in January 1928 in the USA

DTH Comparison

Picture quality

A DTH service is only as good as the picture quality you get. Some players offer MPEG4 picture quality, while others offer DVD quality digital transmission. A newer standard is the MPEG4 with DVB-S2 which stands for Digital Video Broadcasting - Second Generation. This standard was developed at about the same time as the H.264 video codec. The standard has provision for HD quality, but it has to be implemented. It also allows for enhanced interactive services with access to the internet. Only the outgoing data needs to be sent by other transmission methods. Currently, going by information on their web sites, only Airtel and Videocon offer MPEG4 with DVB-S2.

Packages

Each DTH provider has packages with channels bundled together. This seems unfair, since you should be able to pay for only those channels that you want. But it's a small price to pay for digital quality and value added services.

The base pack of almost every provider contains free-to-air channels and a few other channels thrown in. The first level of categorisation in packages happen in two large geographies - South-specific packages and Rest of India packages. Some providers like TataSky schemes are structured in a way that you can add

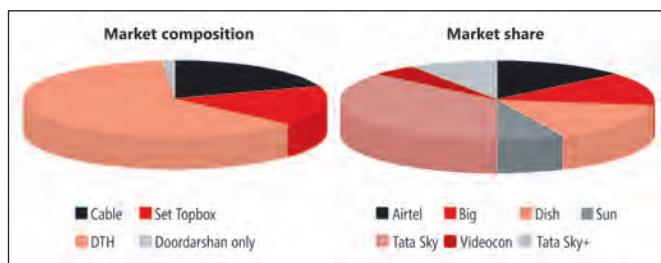
another add-on package to the base pack to make it more comprehensive. Others have fixed plans according to different prices of the packages. Dish TV, for example, has plans such as Silver, Gold and Platinum. In addition to these, providers allow you to add channels *à la carte* (order on an itemised basis). For instance there may be a movies *à la carte* add-on that will activate few foreign movie channels. Almost each DTH provider has special packs for the southern region that has packs specifically designed to include regional language channels. Another option is the all encompassing package. In such a package, DTH providers will give you all channels available for a lump sum amount. These packs are given grandiose names such as Mega-Pack or Titanium Package. On an average, the monthly charges for such a mega pack comes to about Rs.350. Depending on the provider they will even throw in a couple of free movies on demand and perhaps access to active services. The mega packs give the most value for money when it comes to a price per channel. However, if you don't want to go in for jumbo schemes, you need to prioritise which channels are most important. The simplest way to do this is to make a list of the channels you want, and go ahead with the service or package that gives you most of them for the least amount. While looking at a pur-

PACKAGE PRICING AT A GLANCE			
	Package	No of channels	Cost per month
dish tv	Titanium pack	193	332.5
	Child pack	190	165
	Platinum	190	312
	Gold	165	210
	Silver	145	125
	South Platinum	190	312
	South Gold	155	190
	South Silver	145	125
d2h	+ à la carte channels that can be added to any pack		
	Gold Pack	125	150
	Diamond Pack	165	275
	+ Add-ons ranging from Rs. 5 to Rs. 60 that can be added to any of the base packs		
Airtel	Super Value	110	127
	New Value	118	160
	Economy	155	221
	Mega	177	304
	Ultra	184	364
	+ Top ups from Rs 15 to Rs 75 that can be loaded on to any of the packages		
BIG TV	Value Pack	81	90 + Taxes
	Bronze Pack	111	135 + Taxes
	Silver Pack	123	180 + Taxes
	Gold Pack	138	225 + Taxes
	Diamond Pack	152	270 + Taxes
	Platinum Pack	156	315 + Taxes
TATA Sky	+ Add on packs from Rs 25 to Rs 40		
	Super Hit Pack	63	160
	Super Value Pack	103	200
	Super Value Kids Pack	104	225
	Super Saver Pack	124	275
SUN DIRECT	+ Add on packs Rs 15 to Rs 112 + three à la carte channels		
	Shine Pack + 1 free top up	130	120
	North Jumbo Pack	30	300
	+ 41 Add on packs from Rs 6 to Rs 155 + à la carte channels		

chase decision, the number of channels offered is not as important as the relevance of those channels and whether you're getting the desired combination in a pack. There are even interesting entry offers by the DTH providers which include the cost of installing and the hardware. In the entry offers, these providers bundle a particular package for free in the initial months. To make sure you're getting your desired channels, it's best to look through listings on the provider's web site and brochures carefully.

User Interface

The user interface is important. You'll be using it to interact with your service. The Electronic Programming Guide (EPG) helps you navigate through all the programs you can watch. Some EPGs allow you to narrow down channels as per genre. BIG TV's guide, for example, allows you to reorder channels alphabetically or as per numbers. Videocon offers the interface in multiple languages and allows you to customise the on-screen display to a certain



Market share and market composition as per our survey respondents